HIGH PRAISE



Prime Minister Narendra Modi's "Very good job, **(Nara) Lokesh**, *shabash*!" had even the Telugu Desam Party scion and minister blushing even as a visibly pleased father and Andhra Pradesh CM N. Chandrababu Naidu waited nearby. The pat on the back came for the arrangements during the inaugural of the Alluri Sitarama Raju International Airport near Visakhapatnam on August 1. The bonhomie is not new, Modi had similarly praised "Bhai Lokesh" during the record Yogandhra yoga event in Visakhapatnam in June 2025, calling the campaign a model of public participation.

RAIN CHECK



Parliament was debating the country's pressing issues, but Jadavpur MP **Saayoni Ghosh** had other things on her mind, like the pitter-patter of the rain. She posted a light-hearted reel from the rain-soaked Parliament complex, and social media erupted. The ex-Trinamool Congress MP was already under attack for jumping ship and joining the NDA-led treasury benches (along with 19 of her party colleagues); the video further infuriated her critics. Just goes to show how anything can become partisan fodder if the political climate is inclement.

MEME MACHINE



For years, Gorakhpur MP **Ravi Kishan** juggled two careers—as an actor and as a politician. Lately, he seems to have found a third: being full-time meme material. Kishan's dramatic pout, quirky dance moves and dialogues have all become viral GIFs and remixes. So, when he mistakenly referred to the NEET exam paper as a "newspaper", social media acquired another clip to share widely. But unlike many politicians, Kishan has decided to go with the joke. "*Main* viral material *hoon*," he admitted. While image consultants work hard to make politicians relatable, Kishan appears to do so entirely by accident.

Kaushik Deka* with *Jeemon Jacob*, *Ashish Misra*, *Prasad Nichenametla*, *Arkamoy Datta Majumdar* and *Avaneesh Mishra

HEALTH WATCH

MENTAL HEALTH

NATIONAL HOTLINE TO THE RESCUE

By **Sonali Acharjee**

One of India's most significant mental health developments has come through international recognition rather than a new policy announcement. Recently, *The British Journal of Psychiatry* published a paper describing Tele-MANAS (Mental Health Assistance and Networking Across States), the Centre's national tele-mental health helpline, as a model that other low- and middle-income countries could adopt.

Launched in October 2022, Tele-MANAS is a free, round-the-clock telephone service (call 1800-89-14416) that connects people having mental health concerns with trained counsellors. Depending on a caller's needs, they may receive immediate counselling, be referred to a psychologist or psychiatrist, or be guided towards services available in their area. The service is available in multiple languages and allows people to seek help without visiting a clinic. Privacy, easy access and affordability are the hallmarks of its success.

The programme has handled more than 3.43 million calls, underlining two realities. First, there is a substantial unmet need for mental health support in India, with many people seeking help for anxiety, depression, stress and other emotional difficulties. Second, accessible services can encourage more people to reach out. National studies reveal



that 15 per cent of India's adult population suffer from mental health issues, yet the treatment gap ranges from 70-92 per cent, leaving millions without access to care.

The recognition does not mean India's mental health challenges have been solved. Rather, it suggests that simple, tech-enabled services such as Tele-MANAS could become an important first point of contact, helping people access support earlier.